

Microsoft and open source: From 2014 to the present

In 2014, Satya Nadella took charge of Microsoft as CEO and the company's stance on open source changed officially. In a live discussion regarding the company's cloud strategy in San Francisco, Nadella displayed a slide that read 'Microsoft loves Linux'. This ended the decades-long idea of seeing Linux as a competitor and instead seeing it as an ally for boosting development and adopting open source to the core of the enterprise. The same year, Microsoft released the source code of its famous .NET framework in order to boost open source engagement and enhance development.

In 2015, Microsoft co-founded the Node.js foundation and also joined the R foundation. It soon acquired Revolution Analytics and integrated the R programming language to its core products. In the 'All things open' summit, Microsoft delivered a keynote in which it said its strategy with open source was to 'Enable, Integrate, Release and Contribute'.

In 2016, Microsoft acquired Xamarin and released a version of PowerShell for Linux. Microsoft also released a Linux Subsystem for Windows, using which Linux applications could be run on Windows. In the same year, Microsoft invested in the Linux Server technology, which made it a platinum sponsor of the Linux Foundation thus affording the company a seat with the members of the board. Steve Ballmer changed his stance on open source software saying he supports Nadella's policies. Microsoft also announced that it had officially joined the Eclipse Foundation at the EclipseCon of 2016.

In 2018, Microsoft became the platinum sponsor for the Southern California Linux Expo. In the same year, it acquired GitHub, the largest open source code sharing and collaboration platform on the Internet

for US\$ 7.5 billion. This move made Microsoft a frontrunner in the race for open source adaptation. It also fortified the importance and the disruptive nature of the open source paradigm. Microsoft, a company that was once against the concept of open source, ended up becoming its staunch supporter.

In 2021, Microsoft announced Windows 11, in which it showcased the Windows Subsystem for Android that enables Windows users to run Android applications on their computers.

Analysing the pattern

Microsoft's story with open source is far from unique. It is, in fact, typical of big corporations to show resistance or an inability to adapt to paradigm shifting technologies. As a company grows, it gets harder and harder to innovate. It also becomes just as crucial for the survival of the company to do so. Innovation in technology works bottom up. It starts with engineers trying to solve a real-world problem and when a breakthrough technology arrives, it is the outliers, the startups and the DIY mavericks that are the first to adapt to the new technology. When a company is smaller, the risk is lower and that makes it easier to pivot.

The same thing happened with the invention of the Internet. What started as a convenience project for the CERN laboratory in Switzerland has ended up becoming the medium on which all businesses survive today. A similar situation has now arisen with the advent of blockchain technology. What is interesting to note is that in a series of replies to the Halloween

Papers (a series of internal memos and research of Microsoft regarding open source, free software and Linux), Eric S. Raymond wrote about the 'FUD' that surrounded open source. FUD is short for the 'Fear, Uncertainty and Doubt' that comes with the adoption of new technologies. In March 1999, Raymond wrote a letter titled 'The FUD Begins' in his response to Ed Muth's allegation that open source is a weak value proposition. In June 2004, Raymond wrote another letter titled 'Get the FUD' which was his response to the 'Get the facts' campaign by Microsoft.

Presently, FUD is a term used mostly by blockchain enthusiasts and investors to describe the resistance that blockchain based technologies such as cryptocurrencies face. Though many companies such as Amazon, Twitter and Tesla have come to embrace blockchain with open arms, there are many others who are either silent or in opposition to the technology. There is also a lot of fear and uncertainty regarding what the future will look like with the advent of such a technology.

But if there is anything we can learn from this case study, it is the fact that the force of a breakthrough technology is insurmountable. Whether you are a tech giant or a startup, a developer with fifteen years of experience or a newbie just getting started in the industry, only the adaptable get to survive. Open source is one such breakthrough technology, and though Microsoft took its time, it managed to adapt. So if you haven't worked with open source yet, you might as well start now. **END** 🐼

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